

Postpartum - Breast Pain and Engorgement - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1441 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Breastfeeding-related breast pain/engorgement/mastitis assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published mastitis guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the breast pain/redness lasted?
2. [YES_NO] Currently breastfeeding?
3. [TEMPERATURE] What is the temperature, if measured?
4. [YES_NO] If the patient is under 18, can they speak privately now, and do they say they feel safe with the accompanying adult?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Boil (Skin Abscess)

Is this a focal pus-filled skin lump or abscess rather than postpartum breast engorgement or mastitis symptoms?

A focal skin abscess belongs in the Boil (Skin Abscess) pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is the postpartum patient confused, difficult to wake, fainting or collapsing, severely short of breath, blue or grey, having a seizure, unable to keep fluids down and rapidly worsening, or otherwise appearing critically unwell with the breast symptoms?

Altered responsiveness, collapse, severe breathing difficulty, seizure or rapid systemic deterioration can indicate sepsis or another life-threatening postpartum complication and require emergency assessment.

1. Disposition level 70

After emergency features are excluded, is the measured temperature 38 degrees Celsius or higher, is there shaking chills or feeling systemically unwell, is breast redness or swelling spreading rapidly, have symptoms not improved 12-24 hours after home treatment or 48 hours after starting antibiotics, or is this mastitis in someone not breastfeeding?

Postpartum fever and systemic illness require prompt clinical assessment, and NHS.UK mastitis guidance recommends clinical review when symptoms fail to improve or occur outside breastfeeding.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this early engorgement or mild mastitis with no fever, systemic illness, rapid spreading redness, or other features above?

NHS.UK guidance describes continued breastfeeding/expressing, cold compresses, and pain relief as effective first-line self-care.

Advice

Emergency postpartum systemic illness response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now for confusion, reduced responsiveness, collapse, severe breathing difficulty, seizure or rapid critical deterioration. Tell the call handler that the patient gave birth recently and has breast symptoms. Follow emergency instructions and do not self-drive. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: responsiveness or breathing worsens; collapse or seizure; rapid deterioration.

Urgent mastitis review

- Arrange prompt clinical review; the exact non-emergency Qatar destination remains GOVERNANCE_REQUIRED. Antibiotics or further treatment may be needed.
- Call Back If: fever worsens; redness spreads.

Home care for breast engorgement or mild mastitis

- Continue breastfeeding responsively if able, or hand express only enough for comfort if feeding is too painful. Check positioning and attachment, use a cold compress, rest, and avoid deep breast massage, tight clothing, over-expressing, and stopping breastfeeding abruptly. A clinician or pharmacist should confirm any pain medicine is suitable for this patient.
- Call Back If: not improving after 12-24 hours; fever or spreading redness develops.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now for confusion, reduced responsiveness, collapse, severe breathing difficulty, seizure or rapid critical deterioration. Tell the call handler that the patient gave birth recently and has breast symptoms. Follow emergency instructions and do not self-drive. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency

care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Mastitis", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/mastitis/> (page last reviewed 17 March 2023)
- CDC HEAR HER, "Urgent Maternal Warning Signs and Symptoms", <https://www.cdc.gov/hearher/maternal-warning-signs/index.html>
- NHS.UK, "Sepsis", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/sepsis/>

Provenance

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